



Diabetes prevention: 5 tips for taking control

Changing your lifestyle could be a big step toward diabetes prevention — and it's never too late to start. Consider these tips.

By Mayo Clinic Staff

March 12, 2025

Lifestyle changes can help prevent type 2 diabetes, the most common form of the disease. Prevention is especially important if you have a higher risk of type 2 diabetes. For example, you may have a higher risk of the disease if you have excess weight or obesity, high cholesterol, or a family history of diabetes.

If you've been diagnosed with prediabetes — high blood sugar that doesn't reach the level of a diabetes diagnosis — lifestyle changes can prevent or delay type 2 diabetes.

Making a few changes in your lifestyle now may help you avoid serious diabetes health complications in the future. Nerve, kidney and heart damage are a few possible complications you can prevent with some changes. It's never too late to start.

1. Lose extra weight

Losing weight lowers the risk of diabetes. The American Diabetes Association recommends that people with prediabetes lose at least 5% to 7% of their body weight to prevent diabetes. More weight loss can turn into even greater benefits.

People in one large study lowered their risk of developing type 2 diabetes by almost 60% over three years. In this study, they lost about 7% of their body weight with changes in physical activity and diet.

Set a weight-loss goal based on your current body weight. Talk to your healthcare professional about reasonable short-term goals and expectations. For example, aim to lose 1 to 2 pounds a week.

2. Be more physically active

You can gain many benefits from getting regular physical activity, such as:

- Losing weight.
- Lowering your blood sugar.
- Boosting your sensitivity to insulin — which helps keep your blood sugar within a typical range.
- Increasing your aerobic fitness.

Goals for most adults to promote weight loss and keep a healthy weight include:

- **Aerobic activity.** Aim for about 30 minutes or more of moderate aerobic activity — such as brisk walking, swimming or biking — on most days of the week. Get at least 150 minutes of moderate aerobic activity a week. Or get at least 75 minutes of vigorous aerobic activity — such as running or swimming laps — a week.
- **Strength training.** Do strength training for all major muscle groups at least two times a week to increase your strength, balance and skills to keep an active life. Try to spread out your strength training through the week. Strength training can include lifting weights and doing body weight exercises such as squats.
- **Balance training.** For older adults, doing balance training two or three times a week can help keep range of motion and lower the risk of falls.
- **Sit for less time.** Getting up after sitting for a long time, such as sitting at the computer, can help control blood sugar levels. Take a few minutes to stand, walk around or do some light activity every 30 minutes.

3. Eat healthy plant foods

Plants in your diet give you vitamins, minerals and carbohydrates. Carbohydrates include sugars and starches — the energy sources for your body — and fiber. Dietary fiber, also called roughage or bulk, is the part of plant foods your body can't digest or absorb.

Fiber-rich foods promote weight loss and lower the risk of diabetes. Eat a variety of healthy, fiber-rich foods, which include:

- Fruits, such as tomatoes, peppers and fruit from trees.
- Nonstarchy vegetables, such as leafy greens, broccoli and cauliflower.
- Legumes, such as beans, chickpeas and lentils.
- Whole grains, such as whole-wheat pasta and bread, whole-grain rice, whole oats, and quinoa.

Fiber benefits include:

- Slowing the absorption of sugars and lowering blood sugar levels.
- Interfering with the absorption of dietary fat and cholesterol.
- Managing other risk factors that affect heart health, such as blood pressure and inflammation.
- Helping you eat less because fiber-rich foods are more filling and energy rich.

Avoid carbohydrates that are high in sugar with little fiber or nutrients. For example, avoid white bread and pastries, pasta from white flour, fruit juices, and processed foods with sugar or high-fructose corn syrup.

4. Eat healthy fats

Avoid eating many fatty foods that are high in calories. To help lose and manage weight, your diet should include a variety of foods with unsaturated fats. These are sometimes called healthy fats.

Unsaturated fats — both monounsaturated and polyunsaturated fats — promote healthy blood cholesterol levels and good heart and vascular health. Healthy fat sources include:

- Olive, sunflower, safflower, cottonseed and canola oils.
- Avocados.
- Nuts and seeds, such as almonds, peanuts, flaxseed and pumpkin seeds.
- Fatty fish, such as salmon, mackerel, sardines, tuna and cod.

Saturated fats are found in dairy products and meats. These should be a small part of your diet. You can limit saturated fats by eating low-fat dairy products and lean chicken and pork.

5. Skip fad diets and make healthier choices

Many fad diets — such as the glycemic index, paleo or keto diets — may help you lose weight. But there is little research about the long-term benefits of these diets or how they help prevent diabetes.

Your goal for your diet should be to lose weight and then keep a healthier weight moving forward. So healthy decisions about your diet need to include a plan that you can keep as a lifelong habit. Making healthy decisions that reflect some of the foods you like and your traditions may be helpful for you over time.

One simple way to help you make healthy food choices and eat appropriate portion sizes is to divide up your plate. For example, aim for your plate to include these portions:

- One-half: fruit and nonstarchy vegetables.
- One-quarter: whole grains.
- One-quarter: protein-rich foods, such as legumes, fish or lean meats.

When to see your doctor

The American Diabetes Association (ADA) recommends routine screening with tests to diagnose type 2 diabetes for all adults age 35 and older. The ADA also recommends screening for the following groups:

- People younger than 35 who carry excess weight and have one or more risk factors associated with diabetes.
- Women who have had gestational diabetes.
- People who have prediabetes.

- Children who carry excess weight and who have a family history of type 2 diabetes or other risk factors.

Share your concerns about diabetes prevention with your healthcare professionals. They appreciate your efforts to prevent diabetes and may give you more suggestions based on your medical history or other factors.

1. Robertson RP. Prevention of type 2 diabetes. <https://www.uptodate.com/contents/search>. Accessed Oct. 22, 2024.
2. American Diabetes Association. Prevention or delay of type 2 diabetes: Standards of Care in Diabetes — 2024. *Diabetes Care*. 2024; doi:10.2337/dc24-S003.
3. Your game plan to prevent type 2 diabetes. National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases. <https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/diabetes/overview/preventing-type-2-diabetes/game-plan>. Accessed Oct. 22, 2024.
4. Preventing type 2 diabetes. National Institute of Diabetes and Digestive and Kidney Diseases. <https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/diabetes/overview/preventing-type-2-diabetes>. Accessed Oct. 23, 2024.
5. American Diabetes Association. Facilitating behavior change and well-being to improve health outcomes: Standards of Care in Diabetes — 2024. *Diabetes Care*. 2024; doi:10.2337/dc24-S005.
6. Melmed S, et al. Therapeutics of type 2 diabetes. In: *Williams Textbook of Endocrinology*. 15th ed. Elsevier; 2025. <https://www.clinicalkey.com>. Accessed Oct. 23, 2024.
7. Interactive Nutrition Facts label: Dietary fiber. U.S. Food and Drug Administration. <https://www.accessdata.fda.gov/scripts/interactivenutritionfactslabel/dietary-fiber.cfm>. Accessed Oct. 22, 2024.
8. 2020-2025 Dietary Guidelines for Americans. U.S. Department of Health and Human Services and U.S. Department of Agriculture. <https://www.dietaryguidelines.gov>. Accessed Oct. 23, 2024.
9. Interactive Nutrition Facts label: Monounsaturated and polyunsaturated fats. U.S. Food and Drug Administration. <https://www.accessdata.fda.gov/scripts/interactivenutritionfactslabel/fat.cfm>. Accessed Oct. 23, 2024.

10. American Diabetes Association. Diagnosis and classification of diabetes: Standards of Care in Diabetes — 2024. Diabetes Care. 2024; doi:10.2337/dc24-S002.

[Terms & Conditions](#)

[Privacy Policy](#)

[Notice of Privacy Practices](#)

[Notice of Nondiscrimination](#)

[Digital Accessibility Statement](#)

[Advertising & Sponsorship Policy](#)

[Site Map](#)

[Manage Cookies](#)

© 1998-2026 Mayo Foundation for Medical Education and Research (MFMER). All rights reserved.

ART-20047639